

SPORTS SWIRL

By Cy Kritzer

Epstein—A Natural in New York

Buffalo News Staff Reporter

DELAND, Fla., April 13—

Not irreverently, a visitor to the New York Yankees baseball dugout said to Manager Ralph Houk: "John McGraw must be turning over in his grave about this rookie Mike Epstein."

For all his career as manager of the New York Giants in the city with the largest Jewish population in the world, McGraw pursued the super star of Hebraic ancestry.

Andy Cohen came up from the 1927 Buffalo Bisons with superior credentials and the right name, but was on his

way down again in 2 years. Harry Danning also went up from the Bisons several years later and was a regular catcher with a strong bat.

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AFTER MCGRAW'S TIME, Hank Greenberg came from the Bronx to become Detroit's greatest home-run hitter and Sandy Koufax grew up in Brooklyn, but gained his fame in Los Angeles.

"We'd sure like to have Epstein," said Houk, "and would trade high for him. We have the park for him, too (Yankee Stadium with its short right field)."

Even at the cost of another pennant, can the Baltimore

Orioles afford to trade away a bat of Epstein's potential?

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BUT MANAGER HANK Bauer, worried by the sore arms of Jim Palmer, Wally Bunker and Steve Barber, must be thinking.

Epstein has been playing left field but he'll never make it as an outfielder. At first base, Mike's only position, the Orioles have a fixture in Boog Powell and another top first-baseman in Curt Blefary, now playing the outfield.

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EPSTEIN FIGURED on returning to the Rochester Red Wings if the Orioles insisted on him playing the outfield. With him, the Red Wings are the International League pennant favorite, but without him, they're just another ball club.

There are other invisible pressures that could sway a Yankee trade for Epstein. Now that the Yankees are down and struggling, the whole American League is bound to suffer in attendance. Even in 10th place, the Yanks are the best draw on the road.

That can't continue. Another factor could be the New York Mets' superior drawing power in Shea Stadium.

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